**European Commission -
Speech**

Speech by President von der Leyen at the European Parliament plenary debate in preparation of the European Council meeting of 18-19 December 2025, in particular the need to support Ukraine, transatlantic relations and the EU's strategic autonomy

Strasbourg, 17 December 2025

President Metsola, dear Roberta,

Minister Bjerre,

Honourable Members,

This week's European Council is about facing the reality of the moment. The reality of a world that has become dangerous and transactional. A world of wars. A world of predators. The reality of this world means we Europeans must defend ourselves. And we must depend on ourselves. We have been living in this world for some time. Even before the biggest wake-up call of all, Russia's illegal invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. Yesterday's peace is gone. We have no time to indulge in nostalgia. What matters is – how we confront today. We cannot afford to let the world views of others define us. None of us should be shocked by what others say about Europe. But let me say this: It would not be the first time that assumptions about Europe were shown to be outdated. And it would not be the first realisation that the postwar world order is changing beyond recognition. The National Security Strategy is right to say: 'Europe has been losing share of global GDP – down from 25% in 1990 to 14% today.' But what is not written is that the figures for the United States are on the same path. The United States has been losing share of global GDP from 22% in 1990 down to 14% today. So this is not a story of an economy on one side of the Atlantic or the other. This is the story of the shift in the world economy. If you take China alone, their share of global GDP went up from 4% in 1990 to 20% today. This is why the United States has been clear for some time about its shifting strategic interests and priorities as China rises. The point I am making is: This Strategy is not the cause of the disruption that Europe is facing in the world. It is a symptom of the reality of today's world. So our task at this week's Summit is to show that we are focused on our own strategy, our own interests and our own priorities. This is why I want to repeat what I said in this very spot during my State of the Union address: This is Europe's independence moment.

Ever since we started using this term – independence – many have been sceptical about what that entails. Is this even realistic? Just look at what we have already done. From defence to energy, we have made the impossible possible as part of our new reality. And we are ready to do more. Because in our independence, we make ourselves stronger. A stronger Europe is a stronger partner, not just to promote, but to guarantee a safer world.

Let us look at the progress we have made. We are entering a new era, Europe's energy independence from Russian fossil fuels. And this House has been a leader on this from day one. I thank you for that. Your efforts have paid off. Because thanks to REPowerEU, Russian gas imports – LNG and pipeline – are down from 45% at the beginning of the war to 13% today; coal imports are down from 51% at the beginning of the war to now zero; and on crude oil, from 26% at the beginning of the war to 2% today. All this means: We are going to phase out Russian fossil fuels for good and forever. Just a few years ago, this was unthinkable. But we acted. And we earned our independence from Russia. This is not a coincidence. This is hard work that we have done together. And this is hard work that was driven by what makes us European. Our sense of purpose. Our union. Our political will. We now have our template for the way forward. Whether it be on critical raw materials with our RESourceEU plan, or on diversification and strengthening supply chains through ambitious trade agreements from Latin America to the Indo-Pacific. Europe's era of independence must be unstoppable.

And we have more work to do. We have to go further, and we must move swiftly. And that is

particularly important when it comes to defence and security. The bottom line is simple: Europe must be responsible for its own security. This is no longer an option. It is a must. We know the threats that we face, and we will confront them. This means we need to be ready. We have to develop and deploy new capabilities so that we can fight a modern hybrid war. Here again, we are moving mountains. After decades of under-investment, we are turning a corner. We are transforming our defence industrial base into one that can deliver cutting-edge technologies and fast mass production in the cauldron of war. This year, we have done more for defence than in the last decades. Over the last 10 years, we invested EUR 8 billion in the defence fund. This year we enabled up to EUR 800 billion of investment till 2030. And we have seen how oversubscribed our SAFE programme has been – with the demand from 19 Member States fast outstripping the EUR 150 billion on the table. And Member States are already asking for a new round of SAFE. This shows our European commitment to our European security. And this surge is not only about defence, we all know it. It is about our freedom, our prosperity and our independence.

And there is no more important act of European defence than supporting Ukraine's defence. The next days will be a crucial step for securing this. It is up to us to choose how we fund Ukraine's fight. We know the urgency. It is acute. We all feel it. We all see it. Because just as peace negotiations are stepping up, so is intensifying the Russian barrage of attacks.

The IMF and our estimates show that Ukraine's needs for the years 2026 and 2027 are around about EUR 137 billion. Europe should cover two-thirds, that is EUR 90 billion. And this is not just about numbers, this is also about strengthening Ukraine's ability to secure a real peace — one that is just, one that is lasting, one that protects Ukraine and thus also protects Europe.

And it is also about ramping up the cost of war for Russia. This is why I proposed two different options for this upcoming European Council, one based on assets and one based on EU borrowing. And we will have to decide which way we want to take. But one thing is very clear, we have to take the decision to fund Ukraine for the next two years this European Council. And we have already done one important step, last week we agreed on the sustained immobilisation of Russian assets. This is a decisive step that sends a very strong political message. It means that the Russian assets will remain immobilised until we decide otherwise. Until Russia stops the war and until Russia pays duly reparations to Ukraine for all the damages done. With the assets immobilised indefinitely, this is also about strengthening Ukraine's ability to secure a real peace. One that is just, one that is lasting, and one that protects Ukraine and Europe.

Honourable Members,

We also have to agree this week on the topics that have been mentioned by Minister Bjerre. I want to focus on the topics I have mentioned here. We will speak a lot in this debate about the need for European independence and how we achieve it. And this European Council and the decision on Ukraine is a central part of this. But we must always remember why independence is so important in today's world. It is important because independence is ultimately about our freedom. The freedom to decide and make laws for ourselves, to act however we want, to pursue our own interests and our own partnerships. The freedom to vote for whoever we want – without being pressured or subjected to a torrent of manipulated information. The freedom to choose diversity, to choose democracy. But above all it is about the freedom to live the way we want – and that is the European way of life. Our cultures and traditions are so distinct and so central to our way of life. This is what binds us together. And when we are united, we are unstoppable. And I am deeply proud of that. Our differences do not divide us. We celebrate our different cultures. They connect us as Europeans. And the pride we have in Europe is what connects us. So as we look ahead, I urge you to be confident in what we can achieve in our quest to be a strong, independent Europe.

Thank you and long live Europe.

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